Jie Song

University of California, Berkeley
236 Giannini Hall, UC Berkeley
jiesong@berkeley.edu | +1 (202) 262-0027

Education

University of California, Berkeley Expected May 2027
Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics

Georgetown University 2018
Master of Public Policy

The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2016
Bachelor of Social Science in Economics (Honors, First Class)

Research Fields

Urban Economics; Development Economics

References

Professor Thibault Fally
Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
fally@berkeley.edu

Professor Kirill Borusyak
Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
k.borusyak@berkeley.edu

Professor Marco Gonzalez-Navarro
Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
marcog@berkeley.edu

Job Market Paper

Breaking Away: The Endogenous Formation of Local Governments

Abstract: Why do communities form their own governments? In the United States, a community that incorporates chooses its own zoning and municipal public goods and keeps its tax revenue from the rest of the unincorporated county ("remainder"). Using 353 U.S. incorporations from 1970 to 2020, I show that larger places and places Whiter and richer than their county are more likely to incorporate. After incorporation, municipal spending and new construction diverge across the new municipality and their unincorporated neighbor. I estimate a model of local government formation that separates two motives: policies that better fit preferences and keeping the tax base. Holding locations fixed, I find that the average resident of a new municipality gains 0.22% of income: 0.10% from the tax base and 0.12% from zoning net of increased housing costs. Better-fit municipal public goods add almost nothing, as preferences differ far more over zoning. The average resident of the remainder loses 0.013%. A counterfactual rule that additionally requires the remainder to approve halves expected incorporations, and this stops affluent places from leaving. Letting new municipalities compensate the remainder restores most of them: the payment roughly wipes the gain from tax base but leaves the gain from policy fit.

Research in Progress

The Coordination Problem in Transportation Infrastructure Investment

Who Gains from Bringing Government Closer? Evidence from Ethiopia on the Gendered Effects of Decentralization

Other Publications

Biochar Supply-Chain and Challenges to Commercialization
With David Zilberman, David Laird, Coleman Rainey, and Gabriel Kahn.
GCB Bioenergy 15, no. 1 (2023): 7-23.

The Gendered Impacts of Income Fluctuations on Household Departure, Labor Supply, and Human Capital Decisions: Evidence from Kyrgyzstan
With Katrina Kosec, Hongdi Zhao, and Brian Holtemeyer.
Feminist Economics 29, no. 1 (2023): 205-235.

Aspirations and Women's Empowerment: Evidence from Kyrgyzstan
With Katrina Kosec, Kamiljon Akramov, and Bakhrom Mirkasimov.
Economics of Transition and Institutional Change 30, no. 1 (2022): 101-134.

Perceptions of Relative Deprivation and Women's Empowerment
With Katrina Kosec, Cecilia Hyunjung Mo, and Emily Schmidt.
World Development 138 (2021): 105218.

The Effects of Income Fluctuations on Undernutrition and Overnutrition Across the Lifecycle
With Katrina Kosec.
Health Economics 30, no. 10 (2021): 2487-2509.

Teaching Experience

University of California, Berkeley

UC Berkeley Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (2024–2025)

International Trade (Thibault Fally and Edwin Lai)	2023, 2025, 2026
Advanced International Trade (Kirill Borusyak)	2024
Environmental Economics (Steven Sexton and James Sallee)	2023, 2024
Development Economics (Marco Gonzalez-Navarro)	2022

Research Experience and Employment

University of California, Berkeley
Graduate Student Researcher for Andrés Rodríguez-Clare 2022
Graduate Student Researcher for David Zilberman 2021-2022

International Food Policy Research Institute 2018-2020
Research Analyst for Katrina Kosec

World Bank 2017
Research Intern, Procuring Infrastructure: Public-Private Partnerships

Georgetown University 2017
Research Assistant to Andrew Zeitlin and Jacobus Cilliers

Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

2026-2027	Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) grant ($2,500)
2025-2026	Giannini Foundation Mini-Grant ($35,000)
2024-2025	Giannini Foundation Mini-Grant ($25,000); IHS Junior Fellowship ($6,000)
2023-2024	Fisher Center Research Grant ($15,000); IHS Junior Fellowship ($6,000); Elinor Ostrom Fellowship ($3,500); ARE Summer Grant ($3,000); IHS Grant ($1,500)
Earlier	McCourt School Tuition Scholarship ($20,000)

Presentations

2026-2027	UC Berkeley Trade Lunch, Development Workshop, ARE Department Seminar
2025-2026	UC Berkeley Trade Lunch, Development Workshop
2024-2025	UC Berkeley Development Workshop, Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship Meetings
2023-2024	UC Berkeley Development Lunch, Development Workshop, Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship Meetings
2022-2023	UC Berkeley Development Workshop
2019	Sustainability and Development Conference, International Society of Political Psychology Annual Scientific Meeting
2018	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management Student Conference

Professional Service

Refereeing: *World Development* (2); *Feminist Economics* (5)

Mentoring and tutoring 2024-2025
Mentor, Graduate Applications International Network (GAIN)
Tutor, Economists for Equity at Berkeley

Judge, Rausser College Honors Symposium 2023

Languages

English (proficient); Chinese (native)